

Growth and Development Fund

The Growth and Development (G&D) Fund supports GitLab team members in pursuing approved learning experiences that strengthen their skills, support career growth, and contribute to high performing teams. Team members can be reimbursed for up to \$10,000 per calendar year for eligible growth experiences, provided they meet all eligibility requirements.

We've recently updated the G&D process, and are moving away from using issues for G&D submissions, all requests going forward should be submitted via HelpLab.

Here's a quick summary of the changes:

- All new G&D requests must be submitted through HelpLab.
- If you already have a GitLab issue open and it is in progress or already moving through approval, you do not need to resubmit it.
- The fund, budget, eligible uses, and core reimbursement rules are not changing. Reimbursement still goes through Navan.
- HelpLab gives team members clearer tracking and gives leaders better visibility into how G&D funds are being used across their teams.
- Easier tracking means easier to know how much money you have left!

Processing requests via HelpLab allows for better tracking of requests, a clearer structure for submissions, and significantly improves the administration of the Fund.

If you already have a G&D GitLab issue open and it is already in progress or moving through approval, there is no need to resubmit it. Existing GitLab issue-based requests can continue through completion under the prior process.

Reach out to the Talent Development team if you require any assistance with submitting your request.

Eligibility

To use the Growth and Development Fund, applicants must be full-time GitLab employees who meet performance expectations in their role and are not on leave status.

Process

Here is the step-by-step process for submitting and completing a G&D request using HelpLab.

Step 1 - Have a growth conversation

Start by having a growth conversation with your manager to discuss the learning opportunity.

Use this conversation to align on:

- the opportunity itself
- timing and workload impact
- how the request supports your role, career goals, or Individual Growth Plan
- whether there are any department budget implications related to travel

All G&D applications require manager approval, so requests should come out of an ongoing development conversation rather than as a surprise.

Step 2 - Submit your request in HelpLab

Create a new Growth & Development Fund request in HelpLab using the appropriate request path for your opportunity type.

Your request should be submitted at least 30 days in advance of the beginning of your experience when possible.

Be prepared to provide information such as:

- the type of opportunity
- provider or vendor details
- program or event name
- relevant dates
- total cost
- whether the request includes any travel considerations
- how the opportunity supports your development goals

Step 3 - Gain approval

Once submitted, your request will route for approval based on cost tier.

Current approval tiers are:

- Manager approval: \$0 - \$1,000
- Manager + VP approval: \$1,000.01 - \$10,000

Managers should understand what they are approving and be able to explain the reasoning and benefit behind the request.

Step 4 - Make your purchase and complete the opportunity

Once all required approvals have been completed, you may proceed with payment and participation.

In most cases, individual G&D requests should be paid for by the team member who submitted the request unless the specific opportunity type follows a different billing model.

Step 5 - Submit for reimbursement in Navan

In most cases, G&D costs are reimbursed after the opportunity has been completed.

All expenses should be claimed through Navan using the G&D expense type and following the reimbursement requirements for the specific opportunity type.

When submitting your reimbursement, include:

- proof of payment where applicable
- proof of completion where required
- the approved request reference or link from HelpLab once available in the finalized workflow

Travel expenses

Travel, lodging, and meals related to conferences or workshops must be expensed separately from the G&D claim and should follow GitLab's Travel and Expense policy.

These expenses are funded from the requestor's department Travel & Expense budget, not from the G&D allocation.

50% upfront reimbursement

All requests may use the split disbursement option when applicable:

- 50% of the approved opportunity cost can be reimbursed after payment

- the remaining 50% can be reimbursed upon completion

This option does not apply to travel, hotel, or meal expenses.

Step 6 - Close out and share feedback

After reimbursement is complete, close out your request in the final system workflow and share feedback if the experience would be useful for other team members.

Types of Growth and Development reimbursements

Please review the reimbursement section above before proceeding.

Conferences and live workshops

Conference registration fees are eligible for G&D reimbursement.

Travel, lodging, and meals must be expensed separately following the existing travel expense policy.

Academic study

For academic courses relevant to your GitLab career development goals, the G&D Fund can be used to cover tuition and enrollment.

To be eligible, the course must:

- be from an accredited college or university
- result in a final grade equivalent to a "B" or higher

Additional fees related to books, travel, and supplies are not covered under this category.

A final grade report or transcript is required for reimbursement.

Professional development, certifications, and courses

Certifications, licenses, and shorter non-academic courses that are relevant to your development may be reimbursed through the G&D Fund.

A final grade report or satisfactory certificate of completion is required for reimbursement.

Self-service learning subscriptions

Providers such as Coursera, LinkedIn Learning, Reforge, and similar learning subscriptions may be reimbursed when tied to a clear learning goal and intended course usage.

Language courses

Language learning may be eligible when the relevance to job performance is clear.

Code-based learning

GitLab will support coding-related learning opportunities regardless of department when they support development goals.

Programming books

Books related to programming, software development, and technical skills that support career development at GitLab can be reimbursed through the G&D Fund.

Coaching

GitLab is currently contracted with SoundingBoard Coaching and we have a direct relationship with the vendor.

Coaching through the G&D Fund is available to team members at the Manager level and above.

If you are seeking coaching, we strongly encourage you to use SoundingBoard Coaching. Because GitLab has a direct relationship with SoundingBoard, you will not need to put the cost on your personal credit card. The charge can be routed directly to the appropriate cost center.

If you would prefer to use a different coaching vendor, please note that in your request so the team can review it as part of the approval process.

Coaching requests should still follow the current eligibility requirements and any program-specific guidance documented on this page.

Professional dues and memberships

Professional development memberships or dues relevant to your growth and development may be reimbursed.

Parentaly

Parentaly is an expert-led program available globally to all team members planning to go on parental leave - including birthing and non-birthing parents. The program provides personalized 1:1 support before, during, and after leave to help you build a strong coverage plan, transition work effectively, and return to work with confidence. You'll gain access to templates, a personalized toolkit and materials, plus up to nine sessions with a dedicated Parentaly Expert who has supported hundreds of others through parental leave.

Parentaly costs \$2,500 and is funded through your G&D allowance. However, unlike most G&D opportunities, you do not pay upfront and apply for reimbursement. GitLab pays Parentaly directly on your behalf - you simply sign up after receiving manager approval on your G&D issue.

We recommend signing up at least 2-3 months before your leave begins to get the full benefit of the program, though sign-ups are accepted at any point in your leave journey, including when you're returning to work.

Reimbursement Requirements: Parentaly invoices GitLab directly. There is no payment or reimbursement action required from you. After receiving manager approval on your G&D request, proceed directly to sign up for the Parentaly coaching program.

Managers can also access support through Parentaly by activating a Manager Toolkit or attending Manager Training, which provides real-time support and access to guides and resources for leading effectively through parental leave transitions.

Wellbeing

The G&D Fund should not be used for therapy, counseling, mindfulness apps, or similar wellbeing resources. Team members should use Modern Health and related wellbeing resources instead.

Bulk applications

If multiple team members are applying for the same opportunity, submit one request for the group where appropriate, but each team member must still pay for and submit reimbursement for their own expenses.

Company-directed learning opportunities

The G&D Fund supports individual career development chosen by team members. Company-directed or mandatory training should be funded through other appropriate department budgets.

Recoupment policy

If a team member voluntarily terminates employment before completing twelve consecutive months of active employment, academic study or tuition expenses of \$1,000 USD and over must be refunded to GitLab.

This policy applies to academic study reimbursements only. Team members should review this requirement before submitting requests that fall under this category.

Tax implications

In some countries, Growth & Development reimbursements may be considered taxable income. Team members should review the country-specific tax table to understand how reimbursements may be treated in their location.

For team members in the United States, G&D reimbursements are generally not considered taxable income when used for qualifying work-related education expenses. However, individual circumstances may vary.

Contact Payroll with country-specific tax questions.

FAQ

Can I use the G&D Fund to arrange training for my entire team?

No. The G&D Fund is designed for individual career development, and team-wide training should be budgeted outside the G&D Fund.

How can I track my G&D spend?

If you want to know how much of your G&D Fund remains for the calendar year, reach out through the #learninganddevelopment slack channel.

Does budget rollover?

No. Unspent G&D budgets do not roll over from one year to the next.

Can spare budget be shared with other team members?

No. G&D budgets are individual and cannot be shared across team members.

Can I pay for one opportunity over multiple years?

Yes. If an opportunity spans more than one year, costs can be distributed across multiple years, but you still cannot exceed \$10,000 expensed per year.

Links and resources

- [Submit a new G&D request in HelpLab]
- Tax Impacts of Different Growth & Development Benefits